

One can argue that Twitter has always suffered from a lack of business chops when compared to the likes of Facebook in terms of creating business value. But does that mean merely open-sourcing its algorithm will help solve its core business problem? Opening up the Twitter algorithm will allow outsiders to see how Twitter decides to demote or promote posts – this scrutiny is part of Elon Musk’s free speech imperative for the platform going forward. Open-sourcing Twitter’s post ranking and recommendation engine’s algorithm code for viewing isn’t a big deal, I’d imagine, but it’ll come at the cost of revealing the social platform’s secret recipe. This may have potentially serious security repercussions, making Twitter users an easy target for cybersecurity threats – has Elon Musk factored in this unintended consequence of his future roadmap for Twitter? We don’t know for now and only time will tell.

WHY IT’S BAD NEWS FOR ELON MUSK

Elon Musk calls himself a free speech absolutist, and he wants to make Twitter a trustworthy platform that champions the cause of free speech online. He famously tweeted the following, “For Twitter to deserve public trust, it must be politically neutral, which effectively means upsetting the far right and the far left equally.” Is this really the bedrock of Elon Musk’s re-imagination of Twitter? If anything, the new foundation seems to be on shaky grounds from the outset.

Elon Musk has built a stellar reputation as an engineer who’s disrupted the electric vehicles industry with Tesla and re-imagined space flight with SpaceX, but he’s jumping into the social media business with little to no experience. Being an active user of one of the world’s largest social media websites is one thing, buying that website to potentially dictate terms to its entire user base is quite another. Imagine if Twitter is the old schoolyard and Elon Musk is that rich kid who brings all the toys and sports equipment for everyone in the school to

play. If the schoolyard games don’t go according to the rich kid’s liking, he can potentially storm off with all his toys and spoil the fun for everyone else. This isn’t a stretch of anyone’s imagination, several analysts have expressed this very concern at Elon Musk’s purchase of Twitter.

What if Elon Musk chooses to decide which high-profile user can stay on Twitter and who’s booted out? If Twitter handles of prominent media outlets or new media influencers were to be highly critical of Elon Musk’s various business ventures, will their posts and discussions be covertly suppressed? How will this impact the long-term cultural and conversational zeitgeist that Elon Musk’s fundamentally trying

simply because he’s infatuated with it for the longest time. Looking from the outside in, Twitter seems like a broken platform that Elon Musk believes he can fix and turn around quickly and get on to finding some new problem that needs to be fixed. What if he doesn’t find a solution for Twitter as quickly as he thinks he would, and simply gets bored with it all and (gasp) secretly gives up on it? It’s a possibility we shouldn’t be quick to rule out.

IN THE END...

Elon Musk had only to look at Jeff Bezos, and his purchase of The Washington Post newspaper, to see how billionaires who buy powerful entities that control and shape public



What if Elon Musk gets bored or fails?

to promote? Needless to say, navigating this potential minefield of user perceptions and expectations, while trying to be fair, will be Elon Musk’s toughest test till date – tougher than designing rockets or electric vehicles, as complex as they are.

Doesn’t Elon Musk have his work cut out with colonizing Mars through SpaceX and help make humanity a multi-planet species, solve the energy crisis through Tesla cars and gigafactories? Why does he want to distract himself with gate-keeping Twitter of all social media platforms?

Also one can’t help but wonder if Elon Musk has bought Twitter

opinion are perceived – with an increasing degree of suspicion and distrust. As imperfect as Twitter was in playing its part to facilitate global public discourse, at least it wouldn’t have been accused of being controlled by the richest person in the world. By sealing the deal, Elon Musk and Twitter have put each other as the single biggest target on their respective backs. Far from giving each other wings to fly higher than they ever have, their collective weight and the burden of expectations might just sink them faster than an anchor at sea. What a loss it would be to the world, if it were to come to pass! 